



Socrates > Quotes

Socrates quotes (showing 1-30 of 166)

“The only true wisdom is in knowing you know nothing.”

“The unexamined life is not worth living.”

“I cannot teach anybody anything. I can only make them think”

“Wonder is the beginning of wisdom.”

“To find yourself, think for yourself.”

“By all means marry; if you get a good wife, you’ll become happy; if you get a bad one, you’ll become a philosopher.”

“If you don't get what you want, you suffer; if you get what you don't want, you suffer; even when you get exactly what you want, you still suffer because you can't hold on to it forever. Your mind is your predicament. It wants to be free of change. Free of pain, free of the obligations of life and death. But change is law and no amount of pretending will alter that reality.”

“Education is the kindling of a flame, not the filling of a vessel.”

“He who is not contented with what he has, would not be contented with what he would like to have.”

“Know thyself.”

“Strong minds discuss ideas, average minds discuss events, weak minds discuss people.”

“Death may be the greatest of all human blessings.”

“Every action has its pleasures and its price.”

“The way to gain a good reputation is to endeavor to be what you desire to appear.”

“Let him who would move the world first move himself.”

“Do not do to others what angers you if done to you by others.”

“I am not an Athenian nor a Greek, but a citizen of the world.”

“When the debate is lost, slander becomes the tool of the loser.”

“The secret of happiness, you see, is not found in seeking more, but in developing the capacity to enjoy less.”

“Envy is the ulcer of the soul.”

“Employ your time in improving yourself by other men's writings so that you shall come easily by what others have labored hard for.”

“Beware the barrenness of a busy life.”

“We can easily forgive a child who is afraid of the dark; the real tragedy of life is when men are afraid of the light.”

“Thou shouldst eat to live; not live to eat.”

“understanding a question is half an answer”

“The hour of departure has arrived, and we go our separate ways, I to die, and you to live. Which of these two is better only God knows.”

“Be as you wish to seem.”

—

“From the deepest desires often come the deadliest hate.”

“I pray Thee, O God, that I may be beautiful within. ”

“If all our misfortunes were laid in one common heap whence everyone must take an equal portion, most people would be content to take their own and depart.”

“Esteemed friend, citizen of Athens, the greatest city in the world, so outstanding in both intelligence and power, aren't you ashamed to care so much to make all the money you can, and to advance your reputation and prestige--while for truth and wisdom and the improvement of your soul you have no care or worry?”

“In all of us, even in good men, there is a lawless wild-beast nature, which peers out in sleep.”

“The greatest blessing granted to mankind come by way of madness, which is a divine gift.”

“Think not those faithful who praise all thy words and actions; but those who kindly reprove thy faults.”

“Be of good cheer about death, and know this of a truth, that no evil can happen to a good man, either in life or after death.”

“I know that I am intelligent, because I know that I know nothing.”

“True wisdom comes to each of us when we realize how little we understand about life, ourselves, and the world around us.”

“He is richest who is content with the least, for content is the wealth of nature.”

“All men's souls are immortal, but the souls of the righteous are immortal and divine.”

“The easiest and noblest way is not to be crushing others, but to be improving yourselves. ”

“The secret of change is to focus all of your energy, not on fighting the old, but on building the new.”

“Through your rags I see your vanity.”

“Virtue does not come from wealth, but . . . wealth, and every other good thing which men have . . . comes from virtue.”

“One should never do wrong in return, nor mistreat any man, no matter how one has been mistreated by him.”

“The highest realms of thought are impossible to reach without first attaining an understanding of compassion.”

“To be is to do”

“If a man comes to the door of poetry untouched by the madness of the Muses, believing that technique alone will make him a good poet, he and his sane compositions never reach perfection, but are utterly eclipsed by the performances of the inspired madman.”

“I decided that it was not wisdom that enabled [poets] to write their poetry, but a kind of instinct or inspiration, such as you find in seers and prophets who deliver all their sublime messages without knowing in the least what they mean.”

“Well, although I do not suppose that either of us know anything really beautiful & good, I am better off than he is- for he knows nothing & thinks that he knows; I neither know nor think that I

know.”

“Life contains but two tragedies. One is not to get your heart’s desire; the other is to get it.”

“To express oneself badly is not only faulty as far as the language goes, but does some harm to the soul.”

“I did not care for the things that most people care about– making money, having a comfortable home, high military or civil rank, and all the other activities, political appointments, secret societies, party organizations, which go on in our city . . . I set myself to do you– each one of you, individually and in private– what I hold to be the greatest possible service. I tried to persuade each one of you to concern himself less with what he has than with what he is, so as to render himself as excellent and as rational as possible.”

“He who is unable to live in society, or who has no need because he is sufficient for himself, must be either a beast or a god.”

“My friend...care for your psyche...know thyself, for once we know ourselves, we may learn how to care for ourselves" -Socrates”

“God takes away the minds of poets, and uses them as his ministers, as he also uses diviners and holy prophets, in order that we who hear them may know them to be speaking not of themselves who utter these priceless words in a state of unconsciousness, but that God himself is the speaker, and that through them he is conversing with us. ”

“Living well and beautifully and justly are all one thing.”

“Not life, but good life, is to be chiefly valued. ”

“To fear death, gentlemen, is no other than to think oneself wise when one is not, to think one knows what one does not know. No one knows whether death may not be the greatest of all blessings for a man, yet men fear it as if they knew that it is the greatest of evils.”

“For the poet is a light and winged and holy thing, and there is no invention in him until he has been inspired and is out of his senses, and the mind is no longer in him: when he has not attained to this state, he is powerless and is unable to utter his oracles.”

“He is not only idle who does nothing, but he is idle who might be better employed.”

“...money and honour have no attraction for them; good men do not wish to be openly demanding payment for governing and so to get the name of hirelings, nor by secretly helping themselves out of the public revenues to get the name of thieves. And not being ambitious they do not care about honour. Wherefore necessity must be laid upon them, and they must be induced to serve from the fear of punishment. And this, as I imagine, is the reason why the forwardness to take office, instead of waiting to be compelled, has been deemed dishonourable.

Now the worst part of the punishment is that he who refuses to rule is liable to be ruled by one who is worse than himself. And the fear of this, as I conceive, induces the good to take office, not because they would, but because they cannot help — not under the idea that they are going to have any benefit or enjoyment themselves, but as a necessity, and because they are not able to commit the task of ruling to any one who is better than themselves, or indeed as good. For there is reason to think that if a city were composed entirely of good men, then to avoid office would be as much an object of contention as to obtain office is at present...”

“There is no greater evil one can suffer than to hate reasonable discourse.”

“Do not trouble about those who practice philosophy, whether they are good or bad; but examine the thing itself well and carefully. And if philosophy appears a bad thing to you, turn every man from it, not only your sons; but if it appears to you such as I think it to be, take courage, pursue it, and practice it, as the saying is, 'both you and your house.'”

“When you want wisdom and insight as badly as you want to breathe, it is then you shall have it.”

— [Socrates](#)